
Demidius Thorne

Class advancement and prestige-class analysis, levels 17-35

Eighteen prestige classes ranked and analyzed

Prepared from the current character record, campaign rulings, and verified Pathfinder prestige-class text. Conditional epic options are separated from printed-rule fallbacks.

Executive recommendation

Demidius should take **Oracle 18 at character level 18**. Ninth-level Oracle spells are more valuable than any prestige-class entry benefit, and delaying them would weaken every part of his role: fleet commander, social controller, counter-caster, divine support, and emergency problem solver.

After that, take **Evangelist 1-10** and select Oracle as the aligned class. The campaign has confirmed that aligned class can advance Oracle beyond level 20. Evangelist costs one caster level at its first level, then advances spellcasting and every already-possessed Oracle feature that scales with class level on its remaining nine levels. Finish levels 29-35 with Loremaster 1-7 for full spell progression and flexible secrets. The recommended level-35 build is therefore **Oracle 18 / Evangelist 10 / Loremaster 7**.

This guide treats Demidius as the current level-17 Spirit Guide Oracle with the Juju spirit, exceptional Charisma, mythic command abilities, a Profession (sailor) modifier of +113, and the campaign ruling that lets him cast acquired Wizard spells as divine spells. That last rule broadens his spell access; it does not automatically make him an arcane caster for Mystic Theurge prerequisites.

Confirmed ruling and remaining decision gates

Confirmed: Evangelist's aligned class advances Demidius's Oracle progression beyond level 20. Spell progression continues after level 20. Existing revelations and other level-scaling Oracle features continue becoming stronger, but effective Oracle levels above 20 do not create new named Oracle abilities beyond the printed table. Deity-specific prestige classes are legal through patron adaptation.

1. What is the campaign's exact post-20 spell-slot and spells-known schedule?
2. Which nonduplicative Hermes boons occupy Evangelist's three boon slots?
3. Which domains, obedience, and thematic elements replace a printed prestige class's original patron references?

Recommended level-by-level path

Level	Class	Effective Oracle casting	Main gain	Why now
18	Oracle 18	18	Ninth-level spells	The largest immediate power increase available.
19	Evangelist 1	18	Protective grace, prestige entry	This is the class's single lost caster and aligned-class level. Pay it after ninth-level spells.
20	Evangelist 2	19	Aligned class begins	Oracle features resume while Evangelist advances.
21	Evangelist 3	20	First divine boon	Builds the Hermes obedience package without abandoning Oracle progression.
22	Evangelist 4	21	Oracle-aligned advancement	Keeps revelations, curse, spirit-guide features, and epic Oracle progression moving.
23	Evangelist 5	22	Gift of tongues	Excellent for a captain, diplomat, and planar traveler.
24	Evangelist 6	23	Second divine boon	Usually the most strategically important obedience breakpoint.
25	Evangelist 7	24	Multitude of talents	Broadens Demidius's already exceptional competence.
26	Evangelist 8	25	Oracle-aligned advancement	Continues the central chassis rather than replacing it.
27	Evangelist 9	26	Third divine boon	The high-tier Hermes benefit arrives without a second casting loss.
28	Evangelist 10	27	Spiritual form	Strong defensive and mobility capstone, plus the ninth aligned-class advancement.
29	Loremaster 1	28	Secret	Full casting and a customizable payoff.
30	Loremaster 2	29	Lore	Intelligence-based knowledge support is secondary, but casting is preserved.
31	Loremaster 3	30	Secret	Choose a secret that protects action economy or saves.
32	Loremaster 4	31	Bonus language and lore	Campaign breadth rather than raw combat power.
33	Loremaster 5	32	Secret	Another flexible improvement with no caster loss.
34	Loremaster 6	33	Greater lore	Useful in a campaign driven by gods, artifacts, and ancient prophecies.
35	Loremaster 7	34	Secret	Ends at effective Oracle casting 34 with four Loremaster secrets.

The level-35 result is Oracle 18 / Evangelist 10 / Loremaster 7 with effective Oracle casting 34. Evangelist advances Oracle class features nine times, reaching effective Oracle class-feature level 27 before the Loremaster block.

Ranked prestige-class summary

Rank	Grade	Prestige class	Casting progression	Verdict
1	S+	Evangelist	9/10 plus aligned class	Confirmed to advance Oracle beyond 20; it is the definitive post-18 route.
2	S	Stargazer	10/10	Full casting, familiar, hexes, and star-domain tools; patron adaptation makes it fully legal.
3	S-	Exalted	10/10 divine	Full casting, boons, adapted domain access, and a major capstone.
4	A	Veiled Illusionist	10/10	Full casting plus disguises and illusion flexibility that suit Demidius's social-control role.
5	A	Harrower	10/10	Full casting and fate manipulation fit his luck engine, but qualification taxes are real.
6	A-	Loremaster	10/10	Dependable full casting and flexible secrets; less synergy with Charisma than the leaders.
7	A-	Divine Scion	10/10 divine	Strong divine specialization, but alignment and feat requirements must still be satisfied.
8	B+	Enchanting Courtesan	9/10	Excellent covert enchantment tools, but loses a caster level and narrows his identity.
9	B	Envoy of Balance	10/10	Full casting and counter-magic are good; non-patron alignment clauses may still bar entry.
10	B-	Pathfinder Savant	6/7	Broad spell access is normally superb, but Demidius already gains much of it through a campaign boon.
11	B-	Mystery Cultist	9/10	Adapted patron access makes its obedience chassis legal, though it still loses one caster level.
12	B-	Feysworn	9/10	Adapted patron access unlocks strong boons and survival tools, but First World obligations remain.
13	C+	Brewkeeper	9/10	Patron access is legal and spell draughts are useful, but it loses a level and clashes with shipboard needs.
14	C+	Noble Scion	None	Leadership and influence fit the captain, but losing spell progression is too expensive.
15	C	Mortal Usher	5/10 class advancement	Flavorful death-facing champion with modest damage; only half of its levels advance Oracle.
16	D-	Mystic Theurge	10/10 both classes	Demidius does not possess qualifying arcane spellcasting merely because Wizard spells become divine for him.
17	F	Sentinel	None	Martial benefits and obedience boons cannot justify abandoning epic divine casting.
18	F	Hellknight Signifer	10/10	Full casting is deceptive here: its legal, feat, armor, and story costs oppose Demidius's history.

In-depth prestige-class analysis

Evangelist - S+

Evangelist is the only prestige class in this comparison that advances the whole Oracle package rather than only spellcasting. At Evangelist 2, aligned class grants the class features of the selected prior class on every Evangelist level except the first. The campaign has confirmed that this advancement continues Oracle beyond level 20. Demidius therefore advances spellcasting, curse progression, revelations, Spirit Guide features, and the campaign's epic Oracle benefits while also gaining deity boons at levels 3, 6, and 9, broad skill utility, languages, and spiritual form.

Its cost is concentrated and manageable: Evangelist 1 advances neither casting nor Oracle features. Taking Oracle 18 first ensures that this lost level does not postpone ninth-level spells. After that single cost, nine consecutive levels advance Oracle and add Evangelist benefits at the same time. Exalted remains a strong comparison class, but it advances only spellcasting rather than the full Oracle chassis.

Qualification: worship Hermes, remain within one alignment step, possess Deific Obedience, and satisfy one of the skill or spell-entry routes. **Source:** *Inner Sea Gods*, p. 198.

Exalted - S-

Exalted advances divine casting on all ten levels, grants obedience boons at 3, 6, and 9, adds an expanded-portfolio domain at 5, and culminates in a miracle-like divine intervention. That is a powerful, low-risk package for a high-level Oracle because it preserves the most valuable resource: effective spellcasting. It also reinforces Demidius's identity as a favored servant of Hermes.

The drawback is that Exalted advances spellcasting but does not advance Oracle revelations, curse benefits, Spirit Guide, or other class features. The Skill Focus (Knowledge [religion]) tax is also less useful to a Charisma-focused captain. Post-20 spell progression is confirmed, so Exalted remains powerful, but it cannot match Evangelist's continued revelation and Oracle-feature scaling.

Qualification: exactly the deity's alignment, Deific Obedience, Skill Focus (Knowledge [religion]), Knowledge (religion) 5 ranks, and third-level divine spells. Confirm the campaign's Hermes alignment. **Source:** *Inner Sea Gods*, p. 200.

Veiled Illusionist - A

Veiled Illusionist offers full casting while making disguises, glamers, veils, and illusion magic more efficient and flexible. Demidius already wins encounters by controlling information, expectations, emotions, and positioning. This class expands the nonviolent and covert side of that role without reducing his spell progression. It is particularly attractive in political adventures where overt domination would be detected or morally inappropriate.

It ranks below Evangelist and Exalted because it does not advance Oracle-specific systems and asks for an illusion-focused prerequisite package. Demidius is primarily an enchantment and command specialist, so the class is an expansion rather than a direct multiplier. It is a fine secondary block after Oracle 18 or 20 if the campaign emphasizes intrigue.

Qualification: Spell Focus (illusion), Bluff 5, Disguise 5, Knowledge (arcana) 2, and at least three illusion spells including one of second level or higher. **Source:** *Paths of Prestige*, p. 60.

Harrower - A

Harrower preserves full casting and layers fate manipulation onto spells through the Harrow deck. Its suit and alignment mechanics are unusually compatible with Demidius's interest in converting bonuses into luck bonuses and then amplifying or sharing them. In a campaign built around prophecy, discord, divine trials, and strange fate, the narrative fit is also strong.

The class is mechanically busy. It requires the Harrowed feat, multiple skills, a Perform investment, a physical deck, and several divination spells. Some results are less reliable than a direct Oracle feature, and table time can increase if every card effect is resolved slowly. It is best when the player enjoys a variable tactical engine and the GM treats Harrow interactions consistently.

Qualification: non-true-neutral alignment, Harrowed, relevant skills at 5 ranks, third-level spells, three divinations, and a Harrow deck. **Source:** *The Inner Sea World Guide*, p. 276.

Loremaster - A-

Loremaster is the cleanest neutral option: ten levels of full casting, a sequence of customizable secrets, lore abilities, and no allegiance that conflicts with Hermes. Secrets can improve saves, grant feats, or solve a build requirement without sacrificing caster progression. Its broad knowledge identity fits a character who commands a world-traveling ship and negotiates with gods.

The qualification package is expensive: Skill Focus in a Knowledge skill, three metamagic or item-creation feats, two Knowledge skills at 7 ranks, and seven divinations. Its lore abilities are Intelligence-based, while Demidius is built around Charisma. Loremaster is therefore a high-floor fallback rather than the most synergistic ceiling.

Qualification: two Knowledge skills at 7 ranks, three metamagic or item-creation feats, Skill Focus in a Knowledge skill, third-level spells, and seven divinations including one of third level or higher. **Source:** *Pathfinder RPG Core Rulebook*, p. 385.

Divine Scion - A-

Divine Scion maintains full divine casting while specializing in one of the deity's domains. It offers defensive scaling, domain-focused power, and an aura-like divine presence that complements Demidius's extraordinary Charisma. If Hermes's chosen domain matches Demidius's luck or travel engine, the class can turn a broad divine caster into a more focused supernatural commander.

Its problems are eligibility and taxes. It requires exact alignment agreement with the patron deity, Weapon Focus with the favored weapon, Iron Will, and several trained skills. Weapon Focus is a poor use of a feat for a spell-first Oracle. The class is worth considering only if those prerequisites are already present, can be bought cheaply through epic retraining, or directly enable a desired domain specialization.

Qualification: exact patron alignment, Iron Will, Weapon Focus with the favored weapon, relevant skills at 5 ranks, divine spellcasting, and a patron deity. **Source:** *Inner Sea Magic*, p. 46.

Enchanting Courtesan - B+

This class advances casting on nine of ten levels and adds covert casting, social manipulation, touch-based effects, and stronger enchantment or divination use. It directly supports Demidius's face and enchantment roles. Infiltration scenes, negotiations, and controlled social environments are where it can outperform a generic full-casting class despite its lost caster level.

The first lost level is a serious price at epic scale, and the class's intimate-intrigue framing is narrower than Demidius's responsibilities as captain, admiral, protector, and divine champion. Its effects also run into immunity to mind-affecting magic, one of the exact weaknesses the build is trying to mitigate. Use it as a specialized story choice, not the default advancement chassis.

Qualification: Spell Focus in both divination and enchantment, social and magical skills, plus two divinations and two enchantments with at least one of each at second level or higher. **Source:** *Inner Sea Intrigue*, p. 34.

Envoy of Balance - B

Envoy of Balance offers full casting, counterspell tools, and a set of endowments that can answer planar and magical threats. Demidius is already a powerful dispeller and battlefield coordinator, so improving his ability to neutralize enemy magic has strategic value. The class's later defensive options can include exceptional protection against mental intrusion.

Eligibility is the obstacle. The class requires neutrality and contains special restrictions for characters whose spells come from a deity. Depending on Demidius's exact alignment and the campaign's treatment of Hermes, he may not qualify. Even when legal, the balance-centered ethos can conflict with a character actively committed to the New Gods. Rate it B only if the entry text is satisfied without narrative distortion.

Qualification: neutral alignment, qualifying feat, Knowledge (planes) 5, Spellcraft 5, and third-level spells, plus the deity-specific clause. **Source:** *Champions of Balance*, p. 30.

Pathfinder Savant - B-

Pathfinder Savant trades one caster level in a seven-level class for access to spells from other lists, scroll and item mastery, and unusual magical utility. In a normal Oracle build, that breadth can be transformative. It also fits an artifact-rich campaign and a captain who needs answers outside the standard divine list.

Demidius's permanent campaign benefit already lets him learn and cast Wizard spells as divine spells. That removes much of the class's unique advantage. The remaining item and glyph tools do not compensate for another lost caster level unless the GM

interprets esoteric magic more broadly than the existing boon. This is a good class made redundant by Demidius's exceptional campaign rewards.

Qualification: Magical Aptitude, an item-creation feat, Knowledge (arcana) 5, Spellcraft 5, Use Magic Device 5, and second-level spells. **Source:** *Adventurer's Guide*, p. 140.

Noble Scion - C+

Noble Scion offers leadership, influence, resources, and an exceptionally capable servitor. Those benefits align with Demidius's real campaign role: captain of a galleon, employer of a large crew, commander of Thorne Knights, owner of the Kiss from a Rose, and potential political actor in the Isles of Berres.

The class grants no spellcasting. At levels 18-35, each lost Oracle caster level costs spell penetration, dispelling strength, duration, scaling, and whatever epic spell benefits the campaign adopts. Leadership score 53 and multiplied followers already give Demidius far more organizational reach than this class needs to create. It is a narrative option, not an efficient class choice.

Qualification: noble background, Noble Scion feat, and social or knowledge skills. **Source:** *Paths of Prestige*, p. 38.

Mortal Usher - C

Mortal Usher is a ten-level supernatural class whose mortal-talents feature advances a previous class on only the even-numbered levels. It adds reaping-strike damage, psychopomp abilities, and defenses related to death. The themes resonate with a campaign in which Aristea's soul was dragged into Tartarus and the Culling has begun.

Half advancement is too slow for Demidius's central role. Reaping strike is primarily a damage rider, while his greatest contributions are fleet-scale buffs, control, dispelling, and social authority. The class is viable only if the story makes service to the psychopomps more important than optimizing Oracle power.

Qualification: neutral alignment, planar and religious knowledge, and a psychopomp-related deed or relationship. **Source:** *Pathfinder Adventure Path #144*, p. 76.

Mystery Cultist - B-

Mystery Cultist resembles Exalted but serves an empyreal lord. It advances casting on nine levels and grants obedience boons. A suitable celestial patron could produce useful social, luck, or protective abilities.

The campaign's patron-adaptation rule makes the class legal without abandoning Hermes. Its original empyreal-lord references can be mapped to Hermes, while unrelated requirements such as alignment, Celestial language, skill ranks, and the celestial awakening remain relevant. It still loses a caster level and advances no Oracle class features, keeping it below Evangelist, Stargazer, and Exalted.

Qualification: good alignment, Celestial Obedience, Celestial language, Knowledge (religion) 7, empyreal-lord worship, and a celestial awakening. **Source:** *Chronicle of the Righteous*, p. 48.

Brewkeeper - C+

Brewkeeper can distill spells into draughts and use a reservoir to enhance them with metamagic-like effects. The ability to prepare transferable spell effects is tactically interesting for a ship and crew. Nine of ten levels advance casting.

The Cayden Cailean patron restriction can be adapted to Hermes, so it is legal if Demidius meets the remaining alignment, feat, skill, and spell requirements. It still loses a caster level and centers alcohol in a crew where Zujuck turns nearby alcohol into water. The Dawnrunner already has better ways to distribute magic, including Demidius's wide-area ally effects and dedicated support casters.

Qualification: neutral-good or chaotic-good alignment, Cayden Cailean worship, Brew Potion, brewing or alchemy skill, and second-level spells. **Source:** *Paths of the Righteous*, p. 6.

Stargazer - S

Stargazer is excellent: full casting, a familiar, witch hex access, the Stars subdomain, defensive star effects, and additional divine tools. Because spell progression continues after level 20, all ten levels remain valuable rather than becoming mere caster-level increases.

The campaign allows its Pulura requirement to be adapted to Hermes, making the class fully legal. The GM must still map Pulura-specific domain and religious references to an appropriate Hermes package. It ranks below Evangelist because it advances spellcasting but not Demidius's revelation, curse, or Spirit Guide scaling.

Qualification: Pulura worship, specified alignment, and third-level spells. **Source:** *Paths of the Righteous*, p. 30.

Feysworn - B-

Feysworn advances casting on nine levels, grants Fey Obedience boons, and offers resurrection-like ties to an Eldest patron. Some Eldest boon packages include shapeshifting, luck, travel, or social powers that would otherwise appeal to Demidius.

The Eldest patron requirement can be adapted to Hermes, making the class legal. It still loses a caster level and entangles the character's fate with the First World. Its boons and survival tools are real, but Evangelist, Stargazer, and Exalted supply cleaner benefits for Demidius's established identity.

Qualification: Fey Obedience, a fey language, Knowledge (planes) 5, and worship of an Eldest. **Source:** *The First World, Realm of the Fey*, p. 8.

Mystic Theurge - D-

Mystic Theurge advances one arcane and one divine class on every level. It is outstanding when both sides already exist at useful levels and disastrous when a character must take several weak entry levels to qualify. Demidius is an Oracle with a campaign ability that turns learned Wizard spells into divine spells.

That benefit does not itself grant an arcane spellcasting class or qualifying second-level arcane spells. He would need a real arcane-class investment unless the GM explicitly rewrites the prerequisite. Even then, advancing a low-level arcane class is redundant because his Oracle already casts the desired Wizard spells as divine magic.

Qualification: second-level divine spells and second-level arcane spells. **Source:** *Pathfinder RPG Core Rulebook*, p. 387.

Sentinel - F

Sentinel supplies full base attack, martial durability, favored-weapon abilities, and deity boons. It is a respectable class for a divine warrior who casts little or not at all.

It grants no spellcasting progression. Demidius would exchange the strongest epic-scale resource in the campaign for weapon abilities that do not support his existing action economy, Charisma engine, or ship command. The obedience boons are obtainable through much better classes.

Qualification: within one step of the deity, Deific Obedience, Weapon Focus with the favored weapon, and base attack +5. **Source:** *Inner Sea Gods*, p. 202.

Hellknight Signifer - F

Hellknight Signifer provides full casting, armor integration, order abilities, and limited mystery interaction through catechesis. Those mechanics can look attractive on paper.

For Demidius, the class is a categorical mismatch. His childhood was defined by flight from the Hellknights of the Godclaw, and that order remains an enemy tied to his bloodline. The class also demands lawful alignment, armor and feat investment, an initiation killing, and service to an institution opposed to his history. Full casting does not repair those costs.

Qualification: lawful alignment, medium-armor proficiency, an armor-related feat, trained skills, third-level spells, and a witnessed devil-killing trial. **Source:** *Adventurer's Guide*, p. 92.

Confirmed Evangelist progression

The first Evangelist level is deliberately delayed until character level 19. Demidius first takes Oracle 18 and gains ninth-level spells. Evangelist 1 then pays the class's only lost progression level. Evangelist 2-10 advances Oracle from effective class-feature level 18 to 27 while advancing effective Oracle casting to 27. Existing revelations and comparable class-level features continue scaling through those effective levels, but no new named Oracle abilities appear beyond the printed level-20 table. Loremaster 1-7 raises effective casting to 34 without advancing revelations, curse progression, or Spirit Guide features.

Alternative packages

Intrigue campaign

Oracle 18 / Veiled Illusionist 10 / Loremaster 7 produces effective casting 35 and greatly improves infiltration. It gives up Evangelist's Oracle-feature advancement and Hermes boon schedule, but it is mechanically clean and excellent in a politics-heavy arc.

Fate and luck campaign

Oracle 18 / Harrower 10 / Exalted 7 keeps full casting after Oracle 18 and turns Demidius into a more explicit fate manipulator. Confirm how Harrow bonuses interact with his mythic ability that changes bonus types to luck.

Maximum simplicity

Continue Oracle to 35 only as a simplicity benchmark. Spellcasting and existing revelation scaling would continue, but no new named Oracle abilities appear after the printed table. Evangelist is stronger because nine of its ten levels grant that same Oracle scaling while simultaneously adding adapted Hermes boons and Evangelist class features.

Feat and skill preparation

- Preserve Deific Obedience; it is the entry key for Evangelist and Exalted.
- If Loremaster is planned, count existing metamagic and item-creation feats before spending anything. Add Skill Focus (Knowledge) only when the class entry date is firm.
- Maintain Knowledge (religion), Knowledge (planes), Spellcraft, Diplomacy, and Profession (sailor).
- Do not buy Weapon Focus solely for Divine Scion unless the chosen Hermes domain materially improves the build.
- Do not take an arcane dip for Mystic Theurge. The campaign's divine Wizard-spell rule already solves the problem Mystic Theurge would address.

Source links

- Archives of Nethys: Evangelist - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Evangelist>
- Archives of Nethys: Exalted - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Exalted>
- Archives of Nethys: Loremaster - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Loremaster>
- Archives of Nethys: Veiled Illusionist - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Veiled%20Illusionist>
- Archives of Nethys: Harrower - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Harrower>
- Archives of Nethys: Divine Scion - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Divine%20Scion>
- Archives of Nethys: Enchanting Courtesan - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Enchanting%20Courtesan>
- Archives of Nethys: Envoy of Balance - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Envoy%20of%20Balance>
- Archives of Nethys: Pathfinder Savant - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Pathfinder%20Savant>
- Archives of Nethys: Noble Scion - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Noble%20Scion>
- Archives of Nethys: Mortal Usher - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Mortal%20Usher>
- Archives of Nethys: Mystery Cultist - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Mystery%20Cultist>
- Archives of Nethys: Brewkeeper - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Brewkeeper>
- Archives of Nethys: Stargazer - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Stargazer>
- Archives of Nethys: Feysworn - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Feysworn>
- Archives of Nethys: Mystic Theurge - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Mystic%20Theurge>
- Archives of Nethys: Sentinel - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Sentinel>
- Archives of Nethys: Hellknight Signifer - <https://www.aonprd.com/PrestigeClassesDisplay.aspx?ItemName=Hellknight%20Signifer>

Final verdict

Take Oracle 18 immediately, then Evangelist 1-10 with Oracle as the aligned class, followed by Loremaster 1-7. The campaign's confirmation that aligned class advances Oracle beyond level 20 removes the guide's former uncertainty and makes this the clear strongest blend of spellcasting, Hermes devotion, and preservation of Demidius's unique class engine. Avoid prestige classes that offer leadership, melee power, or a second weak casting class at the cost of that confirmed progression.